

Political Appearance as a Causal Cue

A Matched-Identity Candidate Experiment in Finland

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Abstract. Citizens routinely encounter political candidates first as images. This proof of concept identifies whether modifiable political self-presentation—clothing, grooming, hair arrangement, and accessories—causally shapes candidate choice and trait evaluation, and whether those effects depend on congruence with stated policy. Four fictional Finnish identities are each rendered in progressive-coded, neutral, and conservative-coded forms while identity, expression, pose, lighting, age, and background remain fixed. In two paired municipal-election tasks, appearance, economic policy, and sociocultural policy are independently randomized. The design therefore separates an appearance effect from stable facial identity and from the political information attached to the image. It delivers a reusable oTree architecture for a larger preregistered Finland–Chile study, while treating the present images strictly as unvalidated demonstration stimuli.

Motivation and contribution

Facial and bodily appearance can serve as a rapid political cue, particularly when information is limited. Yet appearance is not a neutral measurement device: attractiveness and competence create halo effects in perceived ideology (Herrmann and Shikano, 2016); stereotypically conservative-looking faces can affect candidate support (Olivola et al., 2018); and a dominant-looking face can help with conservative audiences while backfiring among liberals (Laustsen and Petersen, 2016). Appearance also communicates social position. In Finnish municipal elections, upper-class-looking candidates received more votes, while working-class-looking women faced a distinctive penalty (Bahamonde and Sarpila, 2024). These findings imply that the same look need not be universally advantageous. Its meaning should depend on the political message, the audience, and the status boundaries active in a society.

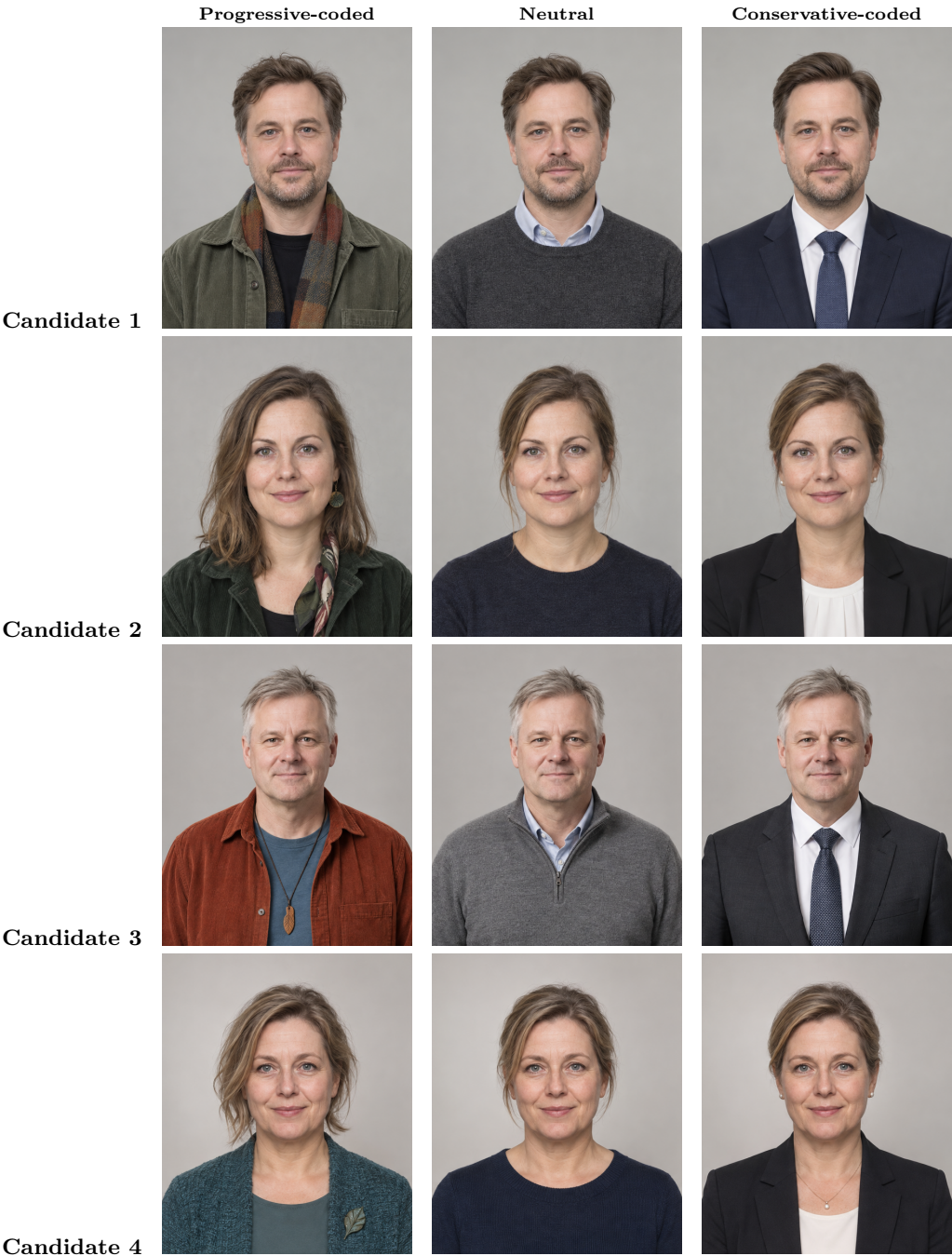
The experiment advances this literature by manipulating *self-presentation within identity*. It asks whether politically coded appearance changes (i) vote choice; (ii) trustworthiness, competence, credibility, authenticity, and political suitability; (iii) perceived ideology; and (iv) perceived appearance–policy fit. Independent randomization turns a multidimensional image-and-policy profile into a causal visual conjoint (Hainmueller et al., 2014; Vecchiato and Munger, 2025). Unlike a text-only profile, the treatment preserves the visual mode in which candidates are commonly encountered.

Design and hypotheses

Four identity-locked portrait triptychs yield $4 \times 3 = 12$ image files. Respondents see two nonrepeating pairs: identities 1–2 in Task 1 and identities 3–4 in Task 2. Appearance $A \in \{-1, 0, +1\}$ denotes progressive-coded, neutral, or conservative-coded presentation. Economic policy $E \in \{-1, +1\}$ and sociocultural policy $S \in \{-1, +1\}$ are independently randomized, as are screen side and the profile rated after each forced-choice vote.

H1: Appearance shifts perceived ideology after policy information is shown. **H2:** appearance–platform congruence increases vote probability, credibility, authenticity, political suitability, and perceived fit. **H3:** production-study effects vary with respondent ideology, class, knowledge, candidate gender, and country.

All proof-of-concept stimuli



Four identity-matched candidates across all three appearance conditions. The crop emphasizes the face, hair, accessories, and upper-body presentation used as visual cues. Condition labels are analytic and are never shown to respondents.

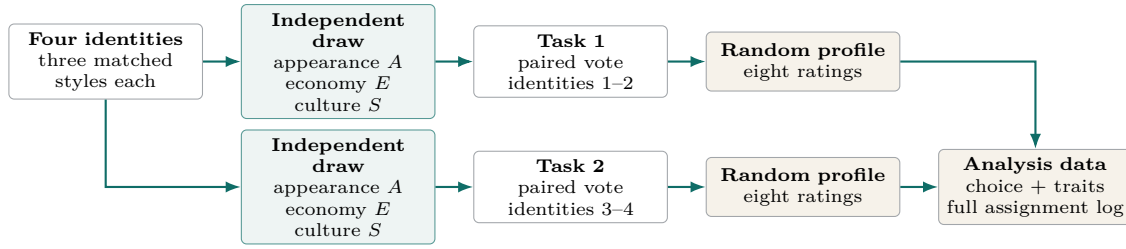


Figure 1: Participant flow. Every respondent sees four portraits across two tasks; no identity repeats.

Causal logic

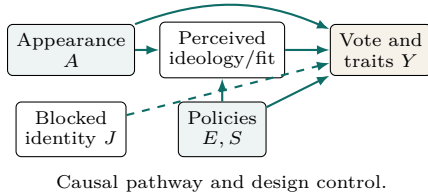
For respondent i , candidate j , and task t , let $Y_{ijt}(a, e, s)$ denote a potential outcome under appearance a , economic policy e , and sociocultural policy s , with identity j held fixed. The appearance AMCE relative to neutral is

$$\tau_a = \mathbb{E}_{E,S,J,T}[Y_{ijt}(a, E, S) - Y_{ijt}(0, E, S)], \quad a \in \{-1, +1\}.$$

For coherent platforms, let $P = -1$ denote economic-left/cultural-liberal and $P = +1$ economic-right/cultural-conservative. The appearance–platform interaction is

$$\tau_G = \{\mu(+1, +1) - \mu(-1, +1)\} - \{\mu(+1, -1) - \mu(-1, -1)\},$$

where $\mu(a, p) = \mathbb{E}[Y \mid A = a, P = p]$. Random assignment identifies both quantities; standard errors cluster by respondent and identity in the production study.



Causal pathway and design control.

Prototype contribution

The prototype delivers identity-matched images, independently randomizes appearance and two policy dimensions, prevents within-person identity repetition, randomizes the rated profile, and exports every assignment with choice time and outcomes. It does not claim that the three looks already possess the intended Finnish meanings.

Before fielding, a Finnish pretest must assess perceived ideology, class/status, attractiveness, apparent age, gender expression, realism, AI artifacts, and resemblance to real people. Selection rules and exclusions should be preregistered: synthetic faces can appear unusually trustworthy (Nightingale and Farid, 2022), while generators can reproduce stereotypes and homogenize groups (AlDahoul et al., 2025).

Why it matters

The design distinguishes appearance from facial identity and tests whether visual presentation corroborates or contradicts political substance. Scaling the identity pool in Finland and Chile reveals whether political appearance is a shared heuristic or a context-dependent route through which classed and gendered boundaries enter representation.

References

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